NEO-REALISM

The realist tradition suffered a setback due to the emergence of the neo-liberal thought, especially the challenge posed by 'pluralism'. State-centrism of the traditional realists received a serious jolt as pluralists emphasized the fact that the state may be a significant actor in international relations but it is not the sole actor. In other words, they acknowledged a plurality of actors in international relations as will be discussed just now. The pluralist's challenge to realism was soon met by a new brand of realists, and the forerunner among them was Kenneth Waltz. Waltz in his famous works, *Man, the State and War* (1959) and *Theory of International Politics* (1979), came up with his idea of world politics which is popularly known as **neo-realism**. Waltz argues that the key difference between international and domestic politics lies not in the regularity of war and conflict but in the **structure** of international system. In the absence of higher authority in the international system, there is no other way to secure oneself other than **self-help** which will ultimately lead to **security dilemma** because security build-up of one would lead to insecurity of others. The resultant anarchy for the neo-realists is, therefore, due to the presence of a system characterized by the absence of a higher power over the sovereign states. It is this structure of international system which decisively shapes up the behaviour of states in international relations and their struggle for power. Thus, the sources of conflict or causes of war, unlike what the traditional or classical realists argue, do not rest on the human nature but within the basic framework of the anarchic structure of international relations. Waltz uses game theory (an economic concept which is widely used in many fields today) in addressing the balance of power and self-help in this environment. He says that balance of power results in this kind of a system irrespective of the intentions of a particular state. But in international politics, in the absence of authority to effectively prohibit the use of force, the balance of power among states becomes most often a balance of capabilities, including physical force, which states choose to use in pursuing their goals. Thus, in a self-help system, the logic of self-interest provides a basis of understanding the problem of